

Nipple Discharge

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Fluid that leaks from one or both nipples is called nipple discharge. Each breast has several (15 to 20) milk ducts. A discharge can come from one or more of these ducts.

(See also [Overview of Breast Disorders](#).)

Nipple discharge can occur normally during the last weeks of pregnancy and after childbirth when breast milk is produced. A nipple discharge can also be caused by breast stimulation in women who are not pregnant or breastfeeding, especially during the reproductive years. However, a nipple discharge in men is always abnormal.

A normal nipple discharge is usually a thin, cloudy, whitish, or almost clear fluid. However, the discharge may be other colors, such as gray, green, yellow, or brown. A bloody discharge is abnormal.

Abnormal discharges vary in appearance depending on the cause. An abnormal discharge may be accompanied by other abnormalities, such as dimpled skin, swelling, redness, crusting, sores, and an inverted (retracted) nipple. (A nipple is inverted if it pulls inward and does not return to its normal position when it is stimulated.) If a discharge from only one breast occurs on its own (without any stimulation of the nipple), it is considered abnormal.

Causes of Nipple Discharge

Several disorders can cause an abnormal discharge.

A discharge from one milk duct or from one breast is likely to be caused by a problem with that breast, such as a noncancerous (benign) tumor or, less commonly, a [cancerous \(malignant\) breast tumor](#).

A discharge from both breasts or from several milk ducts in one breast is more likely to be caused by a problem outside the breast, such as a hormonal disorder or use of certain medications.

Common causes of a nipple discharge

Usually, the cause is a benign disorder of the milk ducts, such as the following:

- A benign tumor in a milk duct (intraductal papilloma)
- Dilated milk ducts (mammary duct ectasia)
- [Fibrocystic changes](#), including pain, cysts, and general lumpiness
- A [breast infection or abscess](#)

Intraductal papilloma is the most common cause. It is also the most common cause of a bloody nipple discharge when there is no lump in the breast.

Less common causes of a nipple discharge

Certain disorders stimulate the production of breast milk in women who are not pregnant or breastfeeding (see table [Some Causes and Features of Nipple Discharge](#)). In most of these disorders, the level of prolactin (a hormone that stimulates production of breast milk) is elevated. Taking certain medications can have the same effect.

Cancer causes fewer than 10% of cases.

Evaluation of Nipple Discharge

Warning signs

Nipple discharge is a cause for concern when it

- Is accompanied by a lump that can be felt
- Is bloody or pink
- Comes from only one breast
- Occurs without the nipple's being squeezed or stimulated by other means (when it occurs spontaneously)
- Occurs in women aged 40 or older
- Occurs in a boy or man

When to see a doctor

If a nipple discharge continues for more than one menstrual cycle or if any of the warning signs are present, women (or men) should see a doctor. Delay of a week or so is not harmful unless there are signs of infection such as redness, swelling, and/or a discharge of pus. Women with such symptoms should see a doctor within 1 or 2 days.

What the doctor does

Doctors first ask questions about a woman's symptoms and medical history. Doctors then do a breast examination. What they find during the history and breast examination often suggests a cause of the discharge and the tests that may need to be done (see table [Some Causes and Features of Nipple Discharge](#)).

To help identify the cause, doctors ask about the discharge and about other symptoms that may suggest possible causes. They ask

- Whether the discharge comes from one or both breasts
- What the discharge's color is
- How long it has lasted
- Whether it is spontaneous or occurs only when the nipple is stimulated
- Whether a [lump](#) or [breast pain](#) is present

Women are also asked whether they have had disorders or take medications that can increase prolactin levels.

Doctors examine the breast, looking for abnormalities, including [lumps](#). If the discharge does not occur spontaneously, the area around the nipples is gently pressed to try to stimulate a discharge.

Doctors also feel the lymph nodes in the armpits and above the collarbone to check for enlarged lymph nodes.



Some Causes and Features of Nipple Discharge

Cause	Common Features*	Tests
Benign breast disorders		
Intraductal papilloma (a benign tumor in a milk duct)—the most common cause	A bloody or pink discharge from one breast	Usually ultrasonography Additional tests, such as mammography, MRI, or a ductogram (mammogram of the milk ducts) depending on the results of ultrasonography Biopsy if other tests cannot rule out cancer
Mammary duct ectasia (dilated milk ducts)	A bloody, pink, or multicolored (puslike, gray, or milky), sometimes thick or sticky discharge from one or both breasts	Same as for intraductal papilloma
<u>Fibrocystic changes</u> (including pain, cysts, and general lumpiness)	A lump, often rubbery and tender, usually developing before menopause Possibly a pale yellow, green, or white discharge	Same as for intraductal papilloma
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An <u>abscess or infection</u>	Pain, tenderness, redness, warmth, or a combination that begins suddenly in a breast Possibly a history of having breast lumps	Breast examination If the discharge does not resolve with treatment, evaluation